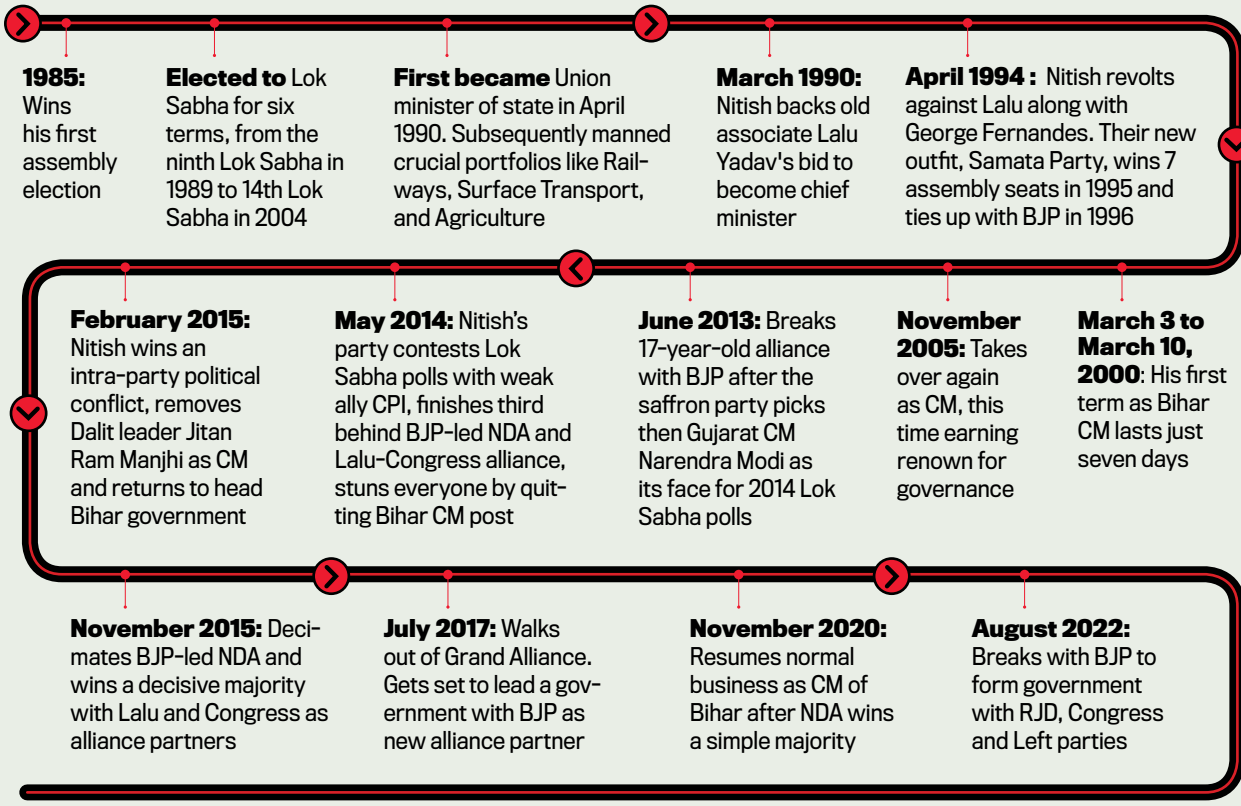


steeled his resolve by then. Even Shah failed to convince Nitish later in the evening, despite assuring him that he would stay undisturbed as the NDA leader in the state. Those who know Nitish well had long read the signals: he was methodically working towards life without the BJP—or after the BJP. Only the saffron party had failed to read his lips in time. On August 9, Nitish first resigned as a CM after a meeting with party legislators, and then staked claim to form an alternative government with the support of seven parties, including Tejashwi Yadav's RJD, the Congress and others—a total strength of 164 MLAs. On August 10, Nitish, already the longest serving chief minister of Bihar, was sworn in once again for a record eighth time—this time threatening to alter political equations beyond his state.

CAUSE FOR DIVORCE

In November 2020, as he recalled in his meeting with JD(U) MLAs on August 9, Nitish had been unwilling to take over as CM. After all, the JD(U) could win only 43 seats—down from 71 in 2015—and the BJP had emerged as the 'Big Brother' with 74. More than that, he suspected this scenario was brought about by a deliberate act of undermining by his partner—Chirag Paswan's LJP, contesting independently outside the NDA, was widely perceived to have been fielded by the BJP strategically to subvert the JD(U)'s chances, and its presence ensured the defeat of at least 25 JD(U) candidates. Even after Nitish was persuaded to give up his reluctance by the BJP national leadership, the tension in the alliance never eased up. For one, there was the constant criticism of his government by BJP leaders—even state president Sanjay Jaiswal consistently kept up hostile Facebook posts and public utterances, with no central leader taking the trouble to shush him. If that was not enough to convince Nitish that all this was by design rather than accident, there came a more grave trigger: in the shape of alleged attempts to poach JD(U) MLAs. The BJP stoutly denies these allegations, with former deputy CM and long-time Nitish partner Sushil Modi calling them "sheer lies". But JD(U) sources say RCP was making concerted attempts to wean away party legislators at the behest of the saffron party. "Inputs started trickling in about RCP reaching out to JD(U) MLAs shortly after he joined the Union cabinet in July 2021. Nitish was alert, and that's why RCP was denied a Rajya Sabha berth this May. This was perhaps when RCP dropped caution and started calling more MLAs," a senior JD(U) leader told INDIA TODAY.

THE FEAR THAT RCP SINGH WOULD 'DO A SHINDE' ON NITISH WAS THE LAST STRAW FOR AN ALLIANCE FRAUGHT FROM DAY ONE

A number of JD(U) MLAs are believed to have submitted audio recordings of phone calls, including WhatsApp calls, that were made to